"are not written in race or ethnicity". It explains why Bose could play a powerful witch in *The Wheels of Time* and Sait speak a fictitious language in *Foundation*. "A lot of the times while casting for international projects," says Joseph, "none of the legacy, the baggage, the stereotyping we may have for someone in India is valid anymore."

You also get a level playing field. "You can have a completely new actor and a big Bollywood superstar vying for the same role," says Joseph. Indian actors, regardless of their star quotient or experience, have to audition to be considered for a role in a US project. Huma Qureshi did so for *Army of the Dead* while Gourav went through five rounds before bagging the central part in *The White Tiger*. "There is a culture of auditioning globally which disappears in India suddenly once you have done a certain amount of work," says Joseph. "Abroad, telling an actor to do a reading to see how they can get into the skin of the character or their chemistry is part and parcel of the casting process. It helps us change the stereotype that if you are auditioning you must still be a struggler and haven't done enough work."

ALL THE WORLD'S A STAGE

What this democratic, nepotism-free process has done is spared talented actors from having to struggle to get a meaty part in India; they can now find it a few thousand miles away and earn decent money too. "Yes, it's good to be spoilt for choice, given that for two to three years, I didn't get any work at all which wasn't very nice," Bose had confessed in a chat last year. "OTT content is giving women like me the opportunity to ask for things I feel are worthy of my craft and hold value."

LOOK FAMILIAR?



NIKESH PATEL
You will know him from rom-coms like *Four Weddings and a Funeral* and Lionsgate Play romcom series *Starstruck*

AMRIT KAUR
The Canadian plays a freshwoman aspiring to be a comedy writer in Mindy Kaling's HBO Max sitcom *The Sex Lives of College Girls* (Amazon Prime Video)



MAITREYI RAMAKRISHNAN



At 17, the Tamil Canadian rookie actor beat thousands to bag the part of Devi in the coming-of-age Netflix comedy series *Never Have I Ever*

SIMONE ASHLEY
After doing episodic parts, Simone Ashwini Pillai a.k.a. Simone Ashley had a career breakthrough as the leading lady in season two of Netflix original *Bridgerton*



RAHUL KOHLI
An integral part now of Mike Flanagan's horror universe, the British actor has been part of Netflix shows *The Haunting of Bly Manor* and *Midnight Mass*



Female actors like Bose and Pallavi Sharda (*Beecham House*), who have carved a niche for themselves abroad, inspire Sait. Her own dream and aspiration to work in the US materialised when *Sacred Games* was nominated for an International Emmy award. In 2019, Joseph would call her to audition for *Foundation*. "It's like appearing for a mock test, which is fun," says Sait of her love for auditions. "Then, you let it be." Helping her along the way was Ali Fazal, who had been through the grind having starred in two international films, *Victoria & Abdul* and *Death on the Nile*. "He has been my cheerleader throughout," says Sait. "When I was waiting for a reply, he'd tell me it'd be okay." Having worked for over a year on *Foundation*, Sait returned richer from the experience. "To be a part of an ensemble cast from all over the world was amazing," she says. "It was colour-, accent- and background-agnostic. I didn't have to alter my accent but just work on the enunciation of certain words."

As proficiency in English gets Indian actors a consideration in American and British shows, they are ensuring they engage agencies abroad to take care of their best interests. Everyone from Bhatt to Sait has international agents negotiating their contracts. Social media platforms like Instagram make it possible for casting calls to be shared online, opening up a realm of possibilities.

Which is why Joseph thinks it's India's moment to shine globally. "If you are talented and willing to put in the work and audition, there is enough opportunity," she says. "In the world of cinema, we are contracting so that we can make the world small enough to make opportunities available for everyone. In doing so, we are expanding the way we see people on screen." ■